

DICKENS, CHARLES



CHARLES DICKENS IS one of the greatest writers in the English language. He was a household name in his own lifetime. His lively descriptions of 19th-century Britain combine with a superb gift for depicting people and their eccentricities, a social conscience, and compassion for the problems faced by ordinary people. He brought to the English novel the ability to portray an entire society in one book. His novels are still loved by readers of all ages.

"Boz"

Scrooge meets the Ghost of Christmas Past

As a young man, Dickens was a journalist, covering Parliament for the *Morning Chronicle*. In 1833 he began to write a series of articles, mostly about London life, using the pseudonym "Boz". These were collected together in *Sketches by Boz* in 1836. Following their success, he was commissioned to write some humorous sporting stories. These appeared in 1836–37 as *The Posthumous Papers of the Pickwick Club* and made Dickens the most famous writer of his day.



Household Words

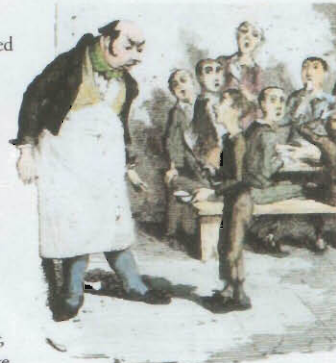
From 1850, Dickens edited and contributed first to the magazine *Household Words*, and then, from 1859, to *All The Year Round*. He used these monthly magazines to publish his latest novel in instalments, reaching a far wider readership than he would have done by simply publishing a book. Both magazines featured works by other famous writers of the time, such as Elizabeth Gaskell and Wilkie Collins. Dickens also included articles about the social problems of his time, such as poor housing and factory accidents.



A Christmas Carol

Ebenezer Scrooge, who refused to celebrate Christmas, and his impoverished clerk Bob Cratchit make *A Christmas Carol* (published in 1843) one of Dickens's most popular novels. Scrooge changes his ways when he witnesses a series of visions, including his own death and the ghosts of Christmas Past, Present, and Future.

In a scene from *Oliver Twist*, Oliver asks for more porridge.

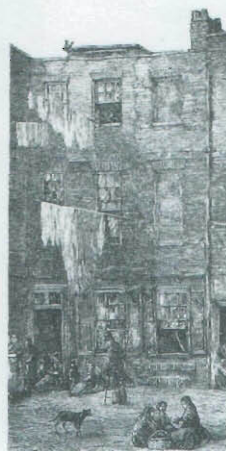


Dickensian London

In Dickens's time, London was a rich city at the centre of the biggest empire the world had ever seen. But many people lived in poverty, making a living from whatever work they could find. Dickens described their suffering, but he loved London – its sights, sounds, and smells feature in all his books.

Social reforms

Dickens often spoke in public about the plight of the poor, the need for educational reform, and the importance of good sanitation to remove the threat of disease. His speeches and novels helped to raise awareness of the need for radical reform, and led to many changes in the law.



London street, 19th century

Public readings

Dickens went on three tours of Britain and one of America, reading selections from his novels. He put vast amounts of energy into these readings, adapting his works specially for public performance, and reading aloud all the parts himself. In 1869, he began a fourth British tour, but his health began to fail, and he died the following year.



Early life

Charles Dickens was born in Portsmouth, England, in 1812. His father was a clerk in the Royal Navy pay office and worked for a time in the royal dockyards in Chatham, Kent, where Charles spent much of his childhood. When his father was imprisoned for debt in London's Marshalsea Prison, Charles, then aged 12, had to take a series of menial jobs in factories and offices. He later used these painful experiences in some of his novels.



David Copperfield

David Copperfield

In 1849–50 Dickens wrote *David Copperfield*, a partly autobiographical novel in which he used his own experiences of an impoverished childhood and menial employment to great effect. Of all his books, it was Dickens' favourite. The novel features Mr Micawber, who is loosely based on Dickens' father. Always in debt, and always waiting for "something to turn up", Micawber is one of the great characters of English literature.

Oliver Twist

The story of Oliver tells of a pauper child of unknown parentage who was brought up in a workhouse and dared to ask for more food. *Oliver Twist* was first published as a book in 1838. The book was later made into a successful musical and film. The story was the first by Dickens to explore the dark side of London life in the 19th century, and the fact that thousands of children were living rough on the streets or in inhuman workhouses.

CHARLES DICKENS

- 1812 Born in Portsmouth, England.
- 1824 Father imprisoned for debt.
- 1836 Marries Catherine Hogarth; publishes *Sketches by Boz*.
- 1836–7 *Pickwick Papers*
- 1838 *Oliver Twist*
- 1839 *Nicholas Nickleby*
- 1850 *David Copperfield*
- 1853 *Bleak House*
- 1857 *Little Dorrit*
- 1858 First reading tour
- 1859 *A Tale of Two Cities*
- 1861 *Great Expectations*
- 1864 *Our Mutual Friend*
- 1870 Dies and is buried in Westminster Abbey.

FIND OUT
MORE

BOOKS

EMPIRES

INDUSTRIAL
REVOLUTION

LITERATURE

UNITED KINGDOM,
HISTORY OF

WRITING